

Broken valves caused a data center to spill 5K gallons of diesel in NJ's Meadowlands - Gothamist

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A mechanical failure caused a leak that led to 5,000 gallons of diesel fuel spilling from a data center into a Meadowlands creek last week. Equinix, the company that has operated the data center in Secaucus since 2001, said its investigation determined there was a failure of two valves that are used as part of the filtration process for the fuel, which was stored in a tank outside the data center. The company said in a statement it regrets that the spill occurred and the concern it has caused, and added that a report on the incident is still being finalized. On Saturday afternoon, the day after the spill occurred, Hackensack Riverkeeper Bill Sheehan said he saw booms being laid across Anderson Creek to contain the spill. In a statement Wednesday, Department of Environmental Protection spokesperson Larry Hajna said the spill impacted a smaller, unnamed tributary near Anderson Creek. The unnamed tributary still empties into the Hackensack River, but Hajna emphasized DEP's determination that the spill had "not impacted the river, Anderson Creek or Anderson Creek's wetlands." Equinix and its contractor Clean Harbors responded to contain the spill and clean it up. Equinix said it is working to ensure a thorough remediation. The New Jersey Department of Environmental Protection has said that the cleanup work is expected to be ongoing this week. The spill sparked concerns from local environmentalists who worried the fuel would taint the Hackensack and the greater ecosystem. Hackensack Riverkeeper Bill Sheehan and Secaucus Mayor Michael Gonnelli have said they want state authorities to pursue a natural resource damages claim against Equinix. The DEP has not yet announced any fines or enforcement action. Swirling debate over data center development in New Jersey and around the nation has put a spotlight on the spill. Opponents of new data centers have said the incident is an example of why New Jersey needs a statewide moratorium on the facilities. This story has been updated with a statement from the Department of Environmental Protection.